

Administrative updates for UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage members in Arizona



For dates of service beginning Jan. 1, 2026, Optum Health Networks, an affiliate of UnitedHealthcare, will manage certain administrative services for the following UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage benefit plans. This reference guide provides an overview of the administrative processes, including how to:

- Verify member eligibility
- Submit and check referral status
- Submit hospital admission notifications
- Submit prior authorization requests
- Check claim status, submit claims and claim reconsiderations

The following benefit plans will be administered by Optum Health Networks, effective Jan. 1, 2026:

Contract number	PBP	Segment ID	Group number
H5253	178	000	90451
H2001	036	000	90927
H2406	062	000	90920
H2406	062	000	06362
H2406	063	000	90811
H2406	076	000	90823
H2406	076	000	90990
H2406	077	000	90824
H2406	078	000	90922
H2406	078	000	06372
H5253	035	000	90653
H5253	035	000	06453
H5253	036	000	90974
H0609	025	000	00345

Contract number	PBP	Segment ID	Group number
H0609	026	000	91038
H0609	026	000	91041
H0609	027	000	00340
H0609	042	000	00337
H0609	042	000	00339
H0609	043	000	00335
H0609	044	000	00332
H0609	045	000	00330
H0609	046	000	00327
H5253	178	000	90452
H2406	062	000	90810
H2406	062	000	06361
H2406	063	000	90924
H2406	076	000	90765
H2406	076	000	90766
H2406	077	000	90825
H2406	078	000	90826
H2406	078	000	06371
H5253	035	000	90108
H5253	035	000	06454
H5253	036	000	90654
H0609	025	000	00344
H0609	026	000	91039
H0609	026	000	91042
H0609	027	000	96001
H0609	042	000	00336
H0609	042	000	00338
H0609	043	000	00334
H0609	044	000	00331
H0609	045	000	00329
H0609	046	000	00326
H0609	808	000	*Any employer groups associated with these H/PBPs

Contract number	PBP	Segment ID	Group number
H0609	807	000	*Any employer groups associated with these H/PBPs

Verifying member eligibility

You can verify member eligibility:

Online: Sign in to the Optum Pro portal at optumproportal.com

Referrals

For plans that require referrals, submit referral requests online at optumproportal.com

Specialist services referrals

Starting **Jan. 1, 2026**, most members enrolled in UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage HMO and HMO-POS plans will be required to obtain a referral from their primary care provider (PCP) before accessing certain specialist services in outpatient, office or home settings.

Applicable markets

This requirement will apply to UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage HMO and HMO-POS plan members delegated to Optum networks in the following markets. To see if a UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage plan member is delegated to your Optum network, check their member ID card. It will list **LIFE1** as the payer ID.

- Arizona
- Colorado
- Connecticut
- Georgia
- Idaho
- Indiana
- Kansas-Missouri
- Nevada*
- New Jersey
- New Mexico**
- New York
- Ohio
- Oregon
- South Carolina
- Tennessee
- Utah
- Virginia
- Washington
- Wisconsin

*Nevada has referral requirements currently in place. Existing referral policies will not change, and referrals are required for all 2026 dates of service. For referral exclusions, requirements and details, please refer to the member's evidence of coverage.

**New Mexico has referral requirements currently in place. The existing referral requirements will be replaced with this new referral policy that includes claim denial. Please see Key dates below for details regarding this update.

What this change means

If you see patients covered by a UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage HMO or HMO-POS plan in one of the applicable markets, they must obtain a referral from their PCP before seeing a specialist. The PCP must submit the referral to Optum prior to the specialist visit.

Referral requirements **do not apply** to members enrolled in:

- Institutional SNP plans
- Erickson Advantage plans
- Michigan Integrated DSNP plan (H2247-005)

The new referral requirements will **not** apply to services provided by a:

- | | | |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------|
| • Audiologist | • Nuclear medicine | • Podiatrist |
| • Chiropractor | • Nutritionist | • Primary care provider |
| • Emergency medicine | • Obstetrician/gynecologist | • Radiologist |
| • Hematologist | • Oncologist | • Therapeutic radiologist |
| • Infectious disease specialist | • Ophthalmologist | • Urgent care |
| • Mental health provider | • Optician | |
| • Neonatology | • Optometrist | |

In addition, a PCP referral is **not required** for:

- PT/OT/ST
- Cardiac or pulmonary rehabilitation services
- Provision of anesthesiology (pain management services rendered by an anesthesiologist do require a referral)
- Home health agency services
- Services performed in an observation setting
- Any services from a pathologist or inpatient consulting physician, including hospitalists
- Emergency room, ambulance or urgent care services
- Same-day or walk-in visits for evaluation and treatment for orthopedic urgent care with a diagnosis of acute fracture, sprain, strain, dislocation or other acute injury
- Telehealth services
- Medicare-covered preventive services, kidney disease education or diabetes self-management training
- Routine annual physical exams, routine vision exams or hearing exams
- Dialysis services
- Any lab services or radiological or non-radiological testing services, including preventive and diagnostic mammograms and colonoscopies
- Durable medical equipment, home health, prosthetic/orthotic devices, medical supplies, diabetic testing supplies, Medicare Part B drugs or allergens
- Additional coverage that may be included by some Medicare Advantage plans but are not covered by Medicare, such as hearing aids, routine eyewear, dental care, fitness memberships or outpatient prescription drugs



What this change means (cont.)

Note, eligibility and benefit verification information and member materials, such as the Evidence of Coverage, may indicate referrals are required for additional benefit categories. However, PCPs are not required to submit referrals for the exclusions listed above, and Optum will not check for referrals for the above categories when paying claims.

Members with an active referral may see providers of the same specialty billing under the same TIN – including physicians, nurse practitioners, physician assistants or other healthcare professionals – without a separate referral.

Additional key information

Claims denied due to missing referrals will be considered provider liability. Members must not be balance billed for services rendered without a valid referral.

Claims may still be denied even if a referral is on file if:

- The services are not covered under the member's benefit plan
- Required prior authorization was not obtained

Learn more

Additional information about the upcoming referral requirement is posted at UHCprovider.com/news.

We're here for you

If you have questions, please contact an Optum Health Networks team member. For technical assistance, contact the support team using the Contact us link in the portal.

Prior authorization

Prior authorization may be required for certain services based on the member's plan. Inpatient and outpatient services generally don't require prior authorization when members are referred to health care professionals who participate with UnitedHealthcare Medicare Advantage PPO.

Services that require prior authorization will be listed at UHCprovider.com/priorauth > Advance Notification and Plan Requirement Resources. Submit your request at least 7 days before the planned date of service:

Online: optumproportal.com

By phone: 877-370-2845

You don't need to submit another prior authorization request if a request was previously reviewed and approved by UnitedHealthcare for dates of service starting Jan. 1, 2026, and after. Optum Health Networks will reimburse services approved by UnitedHealthcare.

Hospital admission notifications

Please notify Optum Health Networks of hospital admissions no later than 1 business day after admission:

Online: optumproportal.com

By phone: 877-778-4108



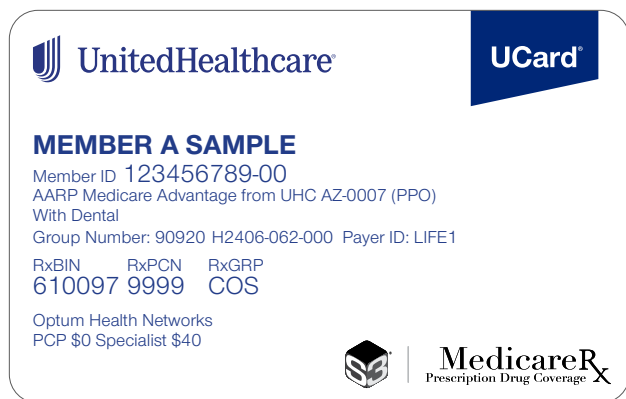
Member ID cards

Members in the affected plans will get new member ID cards that show the Payer ID LIFE1 and will have other applicable delegation-specific descriptors such as delegate name and delegate website listed as the care provider contact. You can download a copy of the member ID card when you verify eligibility and benefits in the [UnitedHealthcare Provider Portal](#).

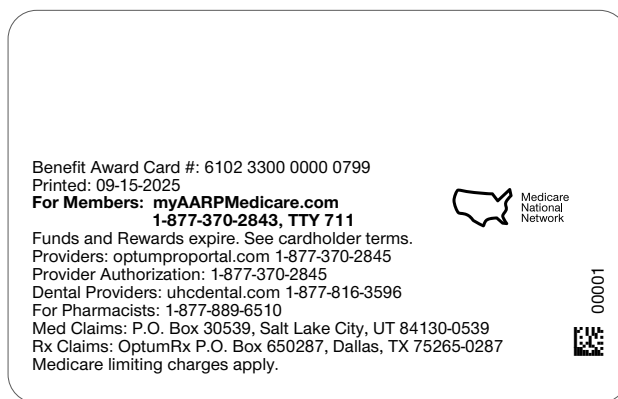
UnitedHealthcare UCard

You can download a copy of the member ID card when you verify eligibility and benefits in the [UnitedHealthcare Provider Portal](#).

- UnitedHealthcare UCard makes it easier for members to access their benefits and programs so they can take advantage of their plan offerings
- UCard does not need to be activated for you to verify eligibility or provide care services to members and should be used in the same manner as any other UnitedHealthcare member ID card
- UCard cannot be used for member out-of-pocket expenses, including copays, coinsurance or deductibles
- Each UCard includes a Benefit Award Card Number, security numbers, expiration dates and a magnetic stripe for in-store purchases or spending rewards – providers do not need to scan the barcode to provide medical, dental, prescription, vision or hearing services to the member
- Payer ID is listed the front of the member ID card
- PCP name and phone number displays on some referral plan ID cards

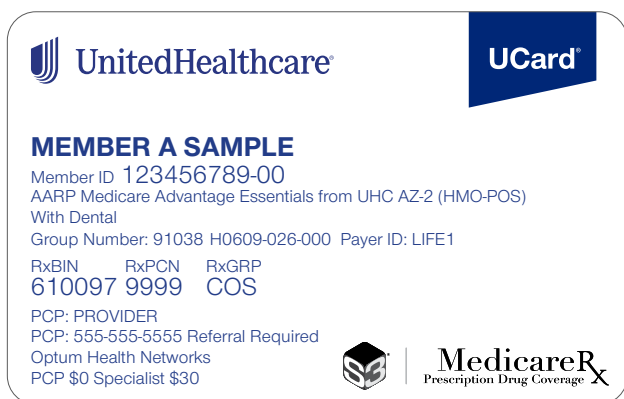


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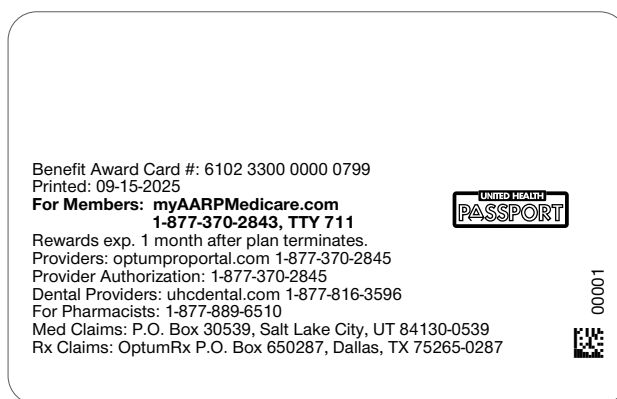


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Sample member ID cards for illustration only; actual information varies depending on payer, plan and other requirements.



front



back

Sample member ID cards for illustration only; actual information varies depending on payer, plan and other requirements.

2026 plan names

Providers can refer to the [Medicare Advantage Benefit Plan Names](#) for the state-specific plan names.

Plan overviews

Plan overviews are available in the [2026 Medicare Advantage, CSNP & DSNP Plan Overview Course](#) > State > Interactive guide.

Summary of benefits

State-specific plan benefits are available at [UHC.com/medicare](#) > Shop Medicare plans > Enter ZIP code > Find plans > View 2026 plans Medicare Advantage plans > Find plan and select view plan details > Plan documents > Summary of benefits.

UnitedHealthcare Medicare National Network and UnitedHealth Passport®

Some HMO and HMO-POS plans with referral requirements have access to the UnitedHealthcare Medicare National Network. For services requiring a referral, referrals are required to any participating network specialist nationwide, including specialists both inside and outside the member's home plan service area. For HMO and HMO-POS plans with referral requirements and the Passport benefit, a PCP referral is not required for Passport services. For more information about National Network and Passport, visit [UHCprovider.com/plans](#) > Choose your state > Medicare > Choose plan > Tools & Resources.

Claims

Submit claims using the following electronic Payer ID or mailing address:

Payer ID: LIFE1

Mailing address:

Optum Care Claims

P.O. Box 30539

Salt Lake City, UT 84130-0539

Submit claim reconsiderations:

Online: optumproportal.com

Check the status of your claim submission:

Online: optumproportal.com



The delegate owns all reconsiderations and appeals when they process claims for a delegated member.



Please don't submit duplicate claims unless you haven't received payment or an explanation of payment within 45 days of submission.



Questions?

For chat options and contact information, visit UHCprovider.com/contactus.